



Boat, Tent or Box **Schools of the World**

Comprehension Questions

1. Why might the author begin by addressing the reader about their school experience?

2. The author gives several reasons for needing an alternative to a school building. Give three of these.

3. How does the author depict first-world education as different from education in the developing world?

4. How do we know that platform schools have been successful?

5. Give one example of an educational provision that has developed to deal with a very specific problem.



6. Why might the writer start the first paragraph after the 'Flooded and Bombed' subheading by recounting a natural disaster in the present tense?

7. According to the writer, why is it important for students and teachers to receive the 'School in a Box' as soon as possible?

8. What is one innovation used in the boat schools programme?

9. Name two difficulties experienced by those running the cave school in China.

10. How did Phymean Noun incentivise parents to send their children to school rather than work?



Extension

- Why is education seen as important throughout the world?
- Research the UN guidelines on education for the world's children - what are they? Why are these guidelines in place? Do you agree that these should be the guidelines for all the world's children? Do you think they go far enough? You might want to look at the Convention on the Rights of the Child for this.
- Unschooling is a relatively new development in education and is particularly popular in the United States. Find out about this educational philosophy. What do the critics say about it? What might the benefits of this system be for children? You might like to consider what Einstein has said about more standard educational practices.

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Comprehension - Answers

1. Why might the author begin by addressing the reader about their school experience?
Answers may vary here but pupils should be thinking about engagement of the reader from the start of the article, introducing the subject of the text and speaking directly to an audience of students rather than adults.
2. The author gives several reasons for needing an alternative to a school building. Give three of these.
A new school might be needed because of a natural disaster, a war or because the children live in an area far away from regular schools. They might also live in an impoverished area where education is too expensive.
3. How does the author depict first-world education as different from education in the developing world?
The author shows education in the developed world as universally available, while education in the developing world is constrained by issues of poverty and war. The author describes it as the 'privilege of the wealthy' and references the problems parents face in providing an education.
4. How do we know that platform schools have been successful?
The author tells us about the growth of the schools from one platform to many; over 6,000 students have been taught at the schools over the last 30 years; the group has expanded to include job training schemes for older pupils.
5. Give one example of an educational provision that has developed to deal with a very specific problem.
A number of different provisions could be mentioned here – refugee camps using the 'School in a Box' programme, the boat schools to combat monsoon weather or the tent schools set up after the earthquakes in Haiti made the school buildings unsafe.
6. Why might the writer start the first paragraph after the 'Flooded and Bombed' subheading by recounting a natural disaster in the present tense?
The writer is trying to achieve an immediacy which puts the reader into the mindset of those who have experienced such hardship.
7. According to the writer, why is it important for students and teachers to receive the 'School in a Box' as soon as possible?
The author mentions the educational and emotional well-being of being involved in a school environment again. Often the pupils cannot utilise the local educational system and would struggle to continue their education. The schools give hope to pupils and parents.
8. What is one innovation used in the boat schools programme?
Innovations include wireless technology, solar panels for electricity and the use of computers in the classroom. The boats allow children to take advantage of the rivers in monsoon season rather than being constrained by it.



9. Name two difficulties experienced by those running the cave school in China.

Birds and bats flew over the classroom; there was no electricity or running water; no teachers wanted to work there; there was little equipment and no money to buy any. The government also chose to close the school since it made Chinese education seem primitive.

10. How did Phymean Noun incentivise parents to send their children to school rather than work?

The offer of free rice and a monthly allowance to make up for the loss of earnings.

Extension

- Why is education seen as important throughout the world?

Education's importance will produce varied responses. Students might also wish to consider the education of boys versus girls and look into those countries in the world where girls' education is not seen as important.

- Research the UN guidelines on education for the world's children - what are they? Why are these guidelines in place? Do you agree that these should be the guidelines for all the world's children? Do you think they go far enough? You might want to look at the Convention on the Rights of the Child for this.

The UNICEF website can help here. Students might also consider whether the Rights, written in the 1990s are still relevant today or whether they need a further update. Students might consider what extra provision they would make to these guidelines - they could imagine being part of a think tank making recommendations on amendments to the original Convention's writings.

- Unschooling is a relatively new development in education and is particularly popular in the United States. Find out about this educational philosophy. What do the critics say about it? What might the benefits of this system be for children? You might like to consider what Einstein has said about more standard educational practices.

Students could look at how this system is different from standard home schooling and where it developed from. They might want to weigh up various alternative provisions alongside this (Montessori and Steiner for example) and consider how these were received when they first appeared as educational theories. Students might debate the pros and cons of each of these systems and consider, if they were to revitalise the educational system of the nation, what system or combination of systems they might recommend.